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Carvaka: Indian atheistic and anti-ritualist outlook holding that sensory perception (***pratyaksha***) is the only authoritative method of obtaining knowledge (***pramana***). They reject inference (***anumana***), as a ***pramana*** in its own right because the limited range of human observations can never guarantee conclusions that are both general and true.

The *Carvakas* recognise the existence of the four material elements: earth, fire, air and water. They deny the soul (***atman***) and say that personal identity is just bodily continuity. Consciousness emerges from physical processes. Feelings are identical with their bodily expressions. The decomposition after death of the body is the absolute and final dissolution of the self.

Of the four legitimate goals of life (***purusartha***), they recognise only economic prosperity (***artha***) and aesthetic and sexual enjoyment (*kama*), and reject social and religious duty (***dharma***) and final release from the series of births (***moksha***). They propose a mild hedonism: 'enjoy yourself while you are alive'. *Carvakas* reject the morally retributive ***karma*** theory since they think that the relation of cause and effect is restricted to what is natural and observable.

Further reading: Cowell and Gough 1996; Franco 1994

Caste (*Varna*): the Brahminical Hindu system of the hierarchical classification of the human world into four kinds of beings: *Brahmins* who are intellectuals and priests; *Kshatriyas*, warriors and rulers; *Vaishyas*, farmers and merchants; *Shudras* who provide various services to members of the higher three estates. Only members of the